COUPLES WORKSHEETS · VOLUME II

# Connection & Conflict

*A Clinical Workbook for Couples — Two session-ready worksheets for couples*

Kejuiana Johnson, MA, LPC, NCC, BC-TMH, CPCS

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# How to Use This Workbook

> **CLINICIAN NOTE**
>
> These two worksheets are designed to be used EARLIER in couples work than the Values & Compatibility set — skills first, depth-of-knowing second. Connection practices build the affective reserve a couple needs; conflict-interruption skills keep that reserve from hemorrhaging during repair cycles. Most couples benefit from 2–3 sessions on each before moving to deeper values work.

## SUGGESTED SEQUENCING

Session 1 — Introduce Worksheet 1 (Building Connection). Complete Parts A and B in session; assign Parts C and D as homework.

Session 2 — Review the rituals and appreciation work; begin integrating into weekly rhythm.

Session 3 — Introduce Worksheet 2 (Interrupting Conflict). Complete Parts A and B in session; pattern-mapping often surfaces strong emotion.

Session 4 — Complete Parts C, D, and E. Role-play the soft startup rewrites and repair attempts in session. Do not send these home to "try out" without first practicing in the room.

## INDICATIONS

Couples reporting emotional distance, reactive conflict cycles, post-argument collapse without repair, bids for connection going unmet, or walking-on-eggshells patterns. Particularly useful for couples who love each other but fight poorly, and for couples rebuilding after rupture.

## CONTRAINDICATIONS

Active intimate partner violence (including coercive control), active untreated affair, or acute safety concerns. Connection rituals and repair language can be weaponized in violent relationships. Stabilize and screen before these worksheets.

## CLINICAL FRAME

Frame these skills as practices, not personality changes. Partners are not being asked to become different people — they are being asked to build small, repeatable interactions that protect the bond. The goal is not conflict elimination; it is conflict that doesn't erode trust.

Worksheet 1

# Building Connection: Love Maps, Bids & Rituals

CLINICIAN NOTE

Connection is not an event. It is the cumulative result of small, repeated acts of knowing, noticing, and turning toward. This worksheet has four parts, best completed in order. Parts A and B can be done in session; Parts C and D benefit from time at home and a return conversation.

| Partner A | Partner B |
|---|---|
| Date: | Session #: |

## PART A — LOVE MAP UPDATE

A love map is your internal picture of your partner's inner world — their worries, hopes, friendships, current stressors, and longings. Love maps go stale; this exercise refreshes yours.

*Instructions: Without asking your partner, write your best guess for each question below. Then share your answers and let your partner correct, confirm, or expand. The goal is not to be right — it is to discover where the map is current and where it's out of date.*

| Question | My best guess |
|---|---|
| My partner's closest friends right now are… | |
| My partner's biggest current source of stress is… | |
| My partner's biggest fear or worry right now is… | |
| One hope my partner holds for the next year is… | |
| My partner's proudest recent accomplishment is… | |
| A childhood memory that still shapes my partner is… | |

| Question | My best guess |
|---|---|
| My partner's relationship with their family of origin is currently… | |
| One thing my partner is grieving, losing, or letting go of is… | |
| My partner's current creative or spiritual interests are… | |
| A dream my partner has that they haven't fully told me is… | |
| The last time my partner felt deeply understood was… | |
| Something my partner needs from me this season that I might not have given is… | |

### LOVE MAP DEBRIEF

1. Which question was easiest? Why do you think that is?

2. Which question was hardest, or which answer did you get most wrong?

3. What did your partner share that you didn't know, and what does that tell you about the current state of your knowing?

### PART B — BIDS FOR CONNECTION

A bid is any attempt — verbal or nonverbal, direct or disguised — to get your partner's attention, affection, humor, or support. Most bids are tiny and easy to miss. Partners who consistently turn TOWARD each other's bids build trust; partners who turn AWAY or AGAINST erode it. Most relationship drift is a slow accumulation of missed bids, not dramatic betrayal.

| The bid | Three ways a partner responds |
|---|---|
| They sigh heavily next to you | Turn toward: "What's on your mind?" / Turn away: ignore / Turn against: "What now?" |
| They point out something out the window | Turn toward: look and engage / Turn away: "mm-hmm" / Turn against: eye roll |
| They send a text mid-day about their day | Turn toward: reply with warmth / Turn away: leave on read / Turn against: terse reply |
| They initiate physical touch | Turn toward: receive, return / Turn away: tolerate but no return / Turn against: flinch, pull back |
| They bring up something they're worried about | Turn toward: ask more / Turn away: change subject / Turn against: minimize or fix-it mode |
| They share a small success | Turn toward: celebrate specifically / Turn away: "that's nice" / Turn against: compare, deflate |

## Your Bid Inventory

*Spend one week paying attention to bids — yours and your partner's. Return to this page and answer:*

1. A bid I made this week that my partner turned toward (and how it felt):

2. A bid I made this week that went unnoticed or was missed (and how it felt):

3. A bid my partner made that I now realize I missed:

4. The shape my bids usually take (words? touch? humor? sighs? questions? gifts?):

5. The shape my partner's bids usually take — what do I need to watch for that I've been missing?

## PART C — RITUALS OF CONNECTION

Rituals are what keep connection from being optional. When a practice is a ritual — predictable, protected, non-negotiable — it does not depend on mood or bandwidth. Design rituals together; make them small enough to survive a bad week.

| Ritual | What we agree to do (be specific) |
|---|---|
| **Daily greeting / parting**<br>*When we leave in the morning and reunite at the end of the day…* | |
| **Daily check-in (stress-reducing conversation, 15–20 min)**<br>*Once a day we will spend protected time hearing about each other's day…* | |
| **Weekly date or touchpoint**<br>*Once a week we will do something together that is not logistics or parenting…* | |
| **Weekly State of the Union (30 min)**<br>*Once a week we'll discuss what's working, what's not, and what each of us needs…* | |
| **Monthly intention ritual**<br>*Once a month we will set shared intentions or review how the month went…* | |
| **Annual review & vision**<br>*Once a year we will step away from daily life and review our life together…* | |
| **Rupture ritual (after a fight)**<br>*After a conflict, the small thing that tells us we are back in contact is…* | |

## PART D — FONDNESS & ADMIRATION

Fondness and admiration are the antidote to contempt. Couples in distress have not necessarily lost their positive feelings — they have lost the habit of speaking them. This exercise is simple and structured on purpose.

### Partner A — Three things I appreciate about you

*Write three specific qualities you appreciate in your partner. For each, include one concrete example of when you saw that quality in action.*

### Partner B — Three things I appreciate about you

*Write three specific qualities you appreciate in your partner. For each, include one concrete example of when you saw that quality in action.*

### Appreciation Delivery

Reading your lists to each other in session is clinically important. Do not paraphrase. Do not deliver your appreciation and immediately qualify it. Do not pair it with a complaint.

For the partner receiving: your only job is to take it in. Not to deflect, not to reciprocate immediately, not to earn it. Let it land.

## ONGOING PRACTICE

The target is one specific, out-loud appreciation per day. Not "you're great." Specific, concrete, small. "Thank you for starting the coffee this morning — I needed the extra five minutes and noticed."

## IN-SESSION PROCESSING (FOR CLINICIAN)

• Watch for partners who turn appreciation into a performance review ("I appreciate that you finally..."). Gently redirect.

• Watch for partners who deflect appreciation with humor, minimization, or "you too." Pause and ask them to simply receive.

• If either partner cannot locate three appreciations, do not push — that is clinical information about where the relationship currently is. Slow down.

• Introduce the "magic ratio" framing (roughly 5 positive interactions per 1 negative for stable relationships) as rationale, not pressure.

Worksheet 2

# Interrupting Conflict: Pause, De-escalate, Repair

CLINICIAN NOTE

Conflict is not the problem; unrepaired conflict is. This worksheet has five parts, in sequence: map your pattern, recognize flooding and use a time-out, soften how you start, build a personal repair menu, and agree on how you return. Part A is best done in session — seeing the pattern laid out on paper often surfaces emotion that needs clinical containment.

| Partner A | Partner B |
|---|---|
| Date: | Session #: |

## PART A — OUR CONFLICT PATTERN

Most couples have one or two recurring fight patterns that show up across topics. The topics change; the choreography doesn't. Naming the pattern is the first step to interrupting it — you can't exit a dance whose steps you haven't seen.

| Stage | What happens |
|---|---|
| **The trigger**<br>*What typically starts it? (Topic, time of day, tone, a specific word, a specific situation.)* | |
| **The first signal**<br>*What's the first sign for ME that I'm getting activated? (Body, thought, impulse.)* | |
| **My escalation move**<br>*What do I typically do as it escalates? (Raise voice, withdraw, criticize, fix, freeze, leave, cry, defend, counter-attack.)* | |

| Stage | What happens |
|---|---|
| **My partner's escalation move**<br>*What do they typically do? (Same categories.)* | |
| **The peak**<br>*What does the peak of our fight look or sound like?* | |
| **The crash**<br>*What happens when it ends — silence, tears, slammed doors, cold shoulder, apologies too quick?* | |
| **The aftermath**<br>*What's the hours-to-days-later pattern? (Distance, over-apology, never mentioned again, next fight seeded.)* | |

## FOUR CONFLICT PATTERNS THAT PREDICT DISCONNECTION

These four patterns, when habitual, predict relationship erosion with remarkable accuracy. Each has a known antidote. Review the table together; circle the pattern most common for you (not your partner).

| Pattern | What it looks like | Antidote |
|---|---|---|
| **Criticism** | Attacking character ("You ALWAYS…" / "You NEVER…") | Gentle startup: describe MY feeling + the specific situation + what I need. |
| **Contempt** | Eye rolls, sarcasm, mocking, name-calling, moral-superiority tone. | Build fondness & admiration; repair quickly; address underlying resentment. |
| **Defensiveness** | "It's not my fault" / counter-attacking / explaining instead of listening. | Take partial responsibility, even for just 10% of the concern. |
| **Stonewalling** | Shutting down, silent treatment, leaving without return, emotional flatline. | Physiological self-soothe, then return. Time-out WITH a return time. |

### My most frequent pattern is:

### The antidote I will practice is:

PART B — FLOODING & THE TIME-OUT PROTOCOL

Flooding is physiological: when heart rate exceeds about 100 bpm (often much higher in reactive partners), the parts of the brain that negotiate, empathize, and listen go offline. No productive conversation is possible in that state. Pushing through flooding doesn't resolve conflict — it cements damage.

## My Flooding Signals

*What tells YOU you're flooded? Circle or add:*

- Heart racing, chest tight, shallow breath
- Jaw clenched, shoulders up, heat in face
- Ears "roaring," voice getting louder or higher
- Thoughts narrowing to "always / never / I'm done"
- Urge to leave, or urge to win at any cost
- Emotional flatline, going blank, "not here"

## Our Time-Out Contract

Time-outs ONLY work if both partners trust the return. A time-out without a return time is abandonment. Design this together.

**Our time-out signal**

*The phrase or gesture we'll use, without escalating, to call a pause. (Examples: "I need 20." / a hand-over-heart gesture / "Yellow light.")*

**How long the pause lasts**

*A minimum of 20 minutes for physiology to reset; a maximum so the pause doesn't become avoidance.*

**What each of us will do during the pause**

*What soothes ME (not rehearsing my case, not texting a friend to rally support). Examples: walk, cold water, breathing, music, shower.*

**How we signal readiness to return**

*A specific phrase or gesture. ("I'm back." / a knock on the door / a text.)*

**What we agree NOT to do during a time-out**

*Don't: keep fighting via text, drink alcohol, post on social, drive while activated, pull in children or friends as allies.*

PART C — SOFT STARTUP

How a conversation begins predicts how it will end. A harsh startup — blame, contempt, or global accusation in the first 30 seconds — predicts a bad ending with ~96% accuracy. Softening the startup is the single highest-leverage skill in couples work.

## The Soft Startup Formula

*I feel _____ about _____ (specific situation, not character). What I need is _____ (specific, doable).*

| Harsh startup (what I might say) | Soft startup (feeling + specific situation + clear ask) |
|---|---|
| *"You NEVER help with the kids in the morning."* | |
| *"You're on your phone again. Great."* | |
| *"Why do I have to remind you EVERY time?"* | |
| *"You don't care about my family at all."* | |
| *A harsh startup I have actually used:* | *My rewrite:* |
| *A harsh startup I have actually used:* | *My rewrite:* |

## PART D — OUR PERSONALIZED REPAIR MENU

A repair attempt is any small gesture that de-escalates a conflict in the moment. Humor, a specific apology, a touch, a word, a look, even a particular joke that's only funny to the two of you. Successful couples don't fight less — they repair faster. This part builds a menu of repairs specific to YOU.

### Partner A — Repairs that work on me

*When I'm activated, the things that help me come back (a specific phrase, a gesture, a tone of voice, a joke, a particular touch):*

### Partner B — Repairs that work on me

*When I'm activated, the things that help me come back (a specific phrase, a gesture, a tone of voice, a joke, a particular touch):*

### Partner A — Attempts that BACKFIRE on me

*Things that are MEANT as repair but escalate me instead. ("Calm down," jokes that land wrong, quick fixes, physical touch when I'm dysregulated, etc.)*

### Partner B — Attempts that BACKFIRE on me

*Things that are MEANT as repair but escalate me instead.*

## Shared Repair Phrases

Draft 3–5 repair phrases you both agree to honor — phrases that, when either of you says them, signal "I'm trying to come back to you, please meet me halfway." Examples: "Can we try that again?" / "I love you, and I'm losing us right now." / "I'm on your side." / "This is hard. Can we slow down?"

**Our agreed repair phrases**

## PART E — THE RETURN CONVERSATION

After a time-out, coming back is its own skill. The temptation is to either pretend the fight didn't happen or to immediately re-prosecute it. Neither works. The return conversation names what happened, takes responsibility for each partner's part, and decides what to do with the original issue.

### The Return Protocol

1. What got activated in me (not what you did wrong):

2. What I own as my part (even just 10%):

3. What I heard you say that I want to make sure I understood:

4. What I want to say differently now that I'm calmer:

5. What we decide to do with the original issue (resolve now, table to a planned time, agree to disagree):

## REFLECTION

1. Looking at our pattern map, what's one small move I could make to interrupt our dance earlier?

2. What repair attempt do I want my partner to believe in, even when it doesn't seem to be working at first?

3. What's one repair I usually WITHHOLD because I feel like I'd be "giving in"? What would it take to give it anyway?

## IN-SESSION PROCESSING (FOR CLINICIAN)

• Role-play the soft startup rewrites and the repair menu in session before sending couples home to try them. Skills that haven't been practiced under the clinician's eye often fail in vivo and feed hopelessness.

• Watch for partners who use the "four horsemen" language as a new weapon against one another. Interrupt this immediately — the framework is a mirror, not a gavel.

• If one partner cannot generate any repair items, explore whether they have authentic access to warmth in the relationship right now. This is clinical information, not failure.

• If time-outs are being used as exits rather than pauses (frequent, long, without return), revisit the contract. Stonewalling-as-time-out is still stonewalling.

• Screen again for IPV before sending couples home with repair language. Coercive partners learn therapy vocabulary quickly; that is not the same as learning repair.

*End of Workbook*

*Prepared by KekeTheLPC • For licensed clinical use in couples therapy*